TOPIC 02 · SKILLS AND RULES
LAB 5 THEME · BUILT-IN SKILLS: VISUAL DESIGN

Lab 5 — Plot and Style Client Growth Charts with Built-in Visual Skills

Maps to	LO2: find, enable and call Copilot's built-in visual skills - chart-design and theme-design - to plot charts from a prompt and style them as one set, and verify what each skill produces
Duration	40 minutes
Tools	Excel · Copilot (Allow editing, Chat only) · Manage plugins & skills · @chart-design · @theme-design
Mock data	data/BrightPath_HR_Outsourcing_Finance.xlsx
Course	Microsoft 365 Copilot for Excel (C34) · v3.2
Prompts	https://tertiarycourses.github.io/C34-Microsoft-365-Copilot-for-Excel/prompts/#lab-5

Goal

Use @chart-design to plot four charts of BrightPath's HR-outsourcing growth, polish them as a set, then use @theme-design to give the whole sheet one professional look - and prove the numbers behind every chart.

What You Will Do

BrightPath's HR-outsourcing business sells monthly payroll and HR services to client companies, and leadership wants four clear charts of how it is growing. You will switch on the built-in visual skills in Manage plugins & skills, then call @chart-design to plot each chart - it picks the chart type and formats it using the Excel design team's guidance - and place all four in a 2 x 2 grid on a new Charts sheet. You will polish the set, ask Copilot for a Checks sheet that proves the numbers behind the charts, and finish with @theme-design to give the sheet one coordinated theme.

What You Will Build

BrightPath_HR_Outsourcing_Finance.xlsx with a Charts sheet of four skill-designed charts in a 2 x 2 grid (MRR and clients, new vs churned clients, H1 2026 spend by channel, active clients by plan), a Checks sheet that agrees with the charts, and one consistent theme

Prerequisites

- Lab 4 completed: you know how rules guide Copilot inside one workbook.
- This lab folder's data/BrightPath_HR_Outsourcing_Finance.xlsx. Skills need Excel's display language set to English.

Data note

Use only the supplied fictional BrightPath data or information you are authorised to process. Do not paste credentials, confidential business material or real employees' personal data into Copilot, rules or skills.

Steps

Step 1. Copy BrightPath_HR_Outsourcing_Finance.xlsx from this lab's data folder into a work-c34 folder on your computer and open it in Excel for Microsoft 365 (desktop). Work on this local copy - no OneDrive upload is needed. Check that Formulas > Calculation Options is Automatic, then open Copilot from the Copilot button on the Home tab or the floating Copilot icon at the bottom right. Read the About_This_Data sheet before you prompt. The workbook holds data only: you will create every chart with a prompt, in a 2 x 2 grid on a new Charts sheet. Read the Definitions row on About_This_Data first.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
Tables : tblClientMonths (18 months) | tblClients (158 clients) | tblSpend (spend by month and channel)
H1 2026 : Jan-Jun 2026
Chart 1 : MRR and active clients by month -> Charts!A1:H18
Chart 2 : new vs churned clients by month -> Charts!J1:Q18
Chart 3 : H1 2026 spend by Channel -> Charts!A20:H37
Chart 4 : active clients by Plan, Jun 2026 -> Charts!J20:Q37
```

Step 2. Turn on the skills. In the Copilot pane select Settings (...) > Manage plugins & skills. Open the Visualisation folder and turn on chart-design (it is off by default). Open the Formatting folder and turn on theme-design - if you have no Formatting folder yet, skip it; Step 7 shows what to do. Leave every other skill as it is. Close the dialog, type @ in the prompt box and confirm chart-design is listed. Then ask Copilot which skills fit this job.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
Where : Settings (...) > Manage plugins & skills - turn on only these
Visualisation : chart-design (off by default)
Formatting : theme-design - only if this folder is shown
Call a skill : type @ and its name, e.g. @chart-design

CHAT ONLY:
Which of your skills would help me choose the right chart for this data and style the finished sheet? Do not change anything.
```

Step 3. Call @chart-design in Allow editing. It chooses and formats the chart using the Excel design team's guidance. Your prompt says where the chart goes and how it should look, because the default placement and style are rarely what you want. Check the values: MRR grows from S$238,200 in Jan 2025 to S$482,200 in Jun 2026, with 131 active clients at the end.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
ALLOW EDITING:
@chart-design On a new sheet named Charts, create a combo chart from tblClientMonths, placed over A1:H18, with MRR as columns and Clients_End as a line on a secondary axis, Jan 2025 to Jun 2026.
Format it cleanly: white background, no border or effects, axis titles with units, and a title that states the finding.
```

Step 4. Add the other three charts, one prompt each, in the same clean style. For chart 2 let the skill recommend the chart type. Check: 98 clients were won and 27 churned over the 18 months; LinkedIn Ads took the most H1 2026 spend (S$191,590) and Referral the least (S$41,440); in Jun 2026 Payroll + HR Admin has 56, Payroll Only has 49, Full HR Outsourcing has 26 active clients.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
ALLOW EDITING:
@chart-design Recommend the best chart for new vs churned clients by month, then create it on
the Charts sheet over J1:Q18 in the same clean style as the first chart.

ALLOW EDITING:
@chart-design Chart the sales and marketing spend for each Channel in H1 2026 (Jan-Jun) from
tblSpend as bars, longest first, on the Charts sheet over A20:H37 in the same clean style.

ALLOW EDITING:
@chart-design Show how many active clients each Plan has in Jun 2026 from tblClients, as the
chart type you think suits it best, on the Charts sheet over J20:Q37 in the same clean style.
```

Step 5. Polish the four charts as one set with a single call. If one chart is not what you wanted, select Undo and ask again for that chart only.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
ALLOW EDITING:
@chart-design Review the four charts on the Charts sheet so they read as one set: a title that
states the finding on each, the same fonts and axis style, data labels only where they help,
and all four the same size.
```

Step 6. Never trust a chart without a check. Ask Copilot to add a Checks sheet with formulas, then compare each value with its chart. If a chart differs, ask the skill which table and filter it used, and fix the chart: the Checks sheet is the reference.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
CHECK (Allow editing):
Add a Checks sheet with formulas that give the MRR and active clients in Jun 2026, the total
new and churned clients over the 18 months, the H1 2026 spend for each Channel, and the active
clients for each Plan, so I can check the four charts.
```

Step 7. Style the workbook with @theme-design (Formatting). It applies one coordinated theme - colours, fonts and formats - to cells, tables and charts. Then steer it with a follow-up prompt. If theme-design is not in your @ list, your account does not have it yet: delete @theme-design and run the prompt as it is. If your organisation has set up a brand kit, try @brandkit instead. Then log your prompts.

PROMPT / CHECK — copy and adapt

```
ALLOW EDITING:
@theme-design Apply one clean, professional theme to the Charts and Checks sheets and all four
charts.

FOLLOW-UP:
@theme-design Use navy #1F4E79 and teal #2A9D8F as the main colours, and keep every chart
readable.

LOG (Allow editing):
Prompt_Log already lists every prompt in this lab. For each one I ran, fill in What Copilot
did and How I verified, and set Decision to Keep. I will tell you any row to change to Revise
or Undo.
```

Sample Prompts

Use these prompts in the Copilot pane (or adapt them). Name the table and columns, state the output, and always verify the result. The same prompts are in sample-prompts.txt in this lab folder.

Copy-ready prompts online:
https://tertiarycourses.github.io/C34-Microsoft-365-Copilot-for-Excel/prompts/#lab-5

#	Purpose	Prompt
1	Find skills	Which skills do you have for charts and formatting? When would I use each one?
2	Chart skill	@chart-design Recommend the best chart for new vs churned clients by month, then create it.
3	Chart skill	@chart-design Chart the sales and marketing spend for each Channel in H1 2026 as bars, longest first.
4	Style skill	@theme-design Apply a coordinated theme to this workbook.
5	Colours	@theme-design Use navy #1F4E79 and teal #2A9D8F as the main colours on every chart.
6	Brand skill	@brandkit Apply our organisation's brand colours and fonts to the charts.
7	Explain	Explain why you chose this chart type for this data, and which other chart types would also work.
8	Question	Which acquisition channel took the most sales and marketing spend in H1 2026, and how much was it?

Test It

Check	Expected result
MRR and active clients, Jun 2026	S$482,200; 131 clients (Jan 2025 MRR S$238,200)
New and churned clients, 18 months	98 new; 27 churned
H1 2026 spend, longest and shortest bar	LinkedIn Ads S$191,590; Referral S$41,440
H1 2026 spend, all channels	S$560,420
Active clients by plan	56 + 49 + 26 = 131
Charts sheet	Four charts in a 2 x 2 grid, one clean style, one theme

Checkpoint

Keep the workbook in work-c34. Lab 6 needs your OneDrive for one thing only: custom skills are stored there.

Troubleshooting

If this happens	Fix
Manage plugins & skills is missing or greyed out.	Wait 10 seconds - it loads after the pane. Then check Excel is up to date and the Office display language is English.
A skill is not listed when I type @.	Turn it on in Manage plugins & skills, or type its full name: an @mention works even when the skill is off.
The chart is in the wrong place or has a border or glow.	Ask: 'Move this chart to the Charts sheet over A1:H18 (use that chart's range), use a white background and remove the border and effects.'
@chart-design builds a different chart type from the one I wanted.	The skill recommends, your words decide. Name the type in the prompt, e.g. 'as bars, longest first'.
@theme-design is not in my list.	Your account may not have the Formatting folder yet. Ask without the skill: 'Apply one consistent colour theme and font to the Charts and Checks sheets and all four charts.'
A chart value differs from the Checks sheet.	Ask: 'Which table, columns and filter did this chart use?' Then fix the chart's data; the Checks sheet is the reference.

Challenge

Ask @chart-design for a fifth chart: monthly gross margin % as a line with the axis starting at 40%. Then use @theme-design so it matches the other four, and check one month's value on Client_Months.

Reflection

Which chart did the skill choose differently from the one you would have drawn, and was it better? What did the theme change that a prompt alone did not?